

‘A misunderstood psychology job’

DJs maintain understanding a crowd is key to setting the vibe for any kind of event.

Sacred site: A Navajo-led tour of Canyon de Chelly takes you places tourists rarely see.



TALIA SPRAGUE/FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

WINTER THEATER

Our Top 10 picks, from Helen Hunt, old-school Steppenwolf and the return of the Lookingglass Theatre. Plus, a look at classical, jazz and experimental music. **A+E**

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Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Debate on future of transit to heat up

Agencies face budget gap, contentious path ahead in Springfield

By Sarah Freishtat
Chicago Tribune

The Chicago area’s four transit agencies are staring down a budget gap that could lead to massive service cuts and fare hikes, and efforts in Springfield to address the challenges are set to heat up this year.

Discussions about the way transit is overseen and how to fund it are likely to gain steam during the new legislative session but the path forward is shaping up to be contentious. A proposal in Springfield to combine the CTA, Metra, Pace and the Regional Transportation Authority has been met with pushback, and a coalition of labor groups is working on an alternate option. The push to boost funding for transit could be complicated by a projected multibillion-dollar deficit in Illinois’ next budget and competing requests from Chicago, such as a potential ask for more Chicago Public Schools funding and a package for a new Bears stadium.

Hanging in the balance is the prospect of a 40% cut in service across the CTA, Metra and Pace, according to the Regional Transportation Authority, which is calling for a significant influx of new money for transit. That would turn a 15-minute wait for a bus in the city into a 25-minute wait, and a 45-minute wait for a bus in the suburbs into a wait of more than an hour. A Metra line that once had 90 trains per day would be cut to 54, according to RTA estimates.

That’s what could happen if the region fails to fill a \$771 million budget gap the four agencies will face when federal COVID-19 relief funding dries up, the RTA warned. The agency, along with some other regional planners and officials, is calling on Springfield to not just fill the gap, but find \$1.5 billion in new funding to overhaul the system.

With federal aid expected to dry up early next year, tackling transit’s challenges is taking on increasing urgency.

“It needs to be dealt with this (legislative) session, and hopefully in a meaningful way,” said Audrey Wennink, transportation director for the Metropolitan Planning Council. “If it’s not, then Pace and



A FRAGILE HAVEN

Venezuelan migrants face violence and uncertainty at Chicago housing complex

By Nell Salzman
and Armando L. Sanchez
Chicago Tribune

Kelvis Sanchez has lived in fear for so long that he no longer reacts to the sounds of gunshots, screams or windows breaking that ordinarily would have terrified him.

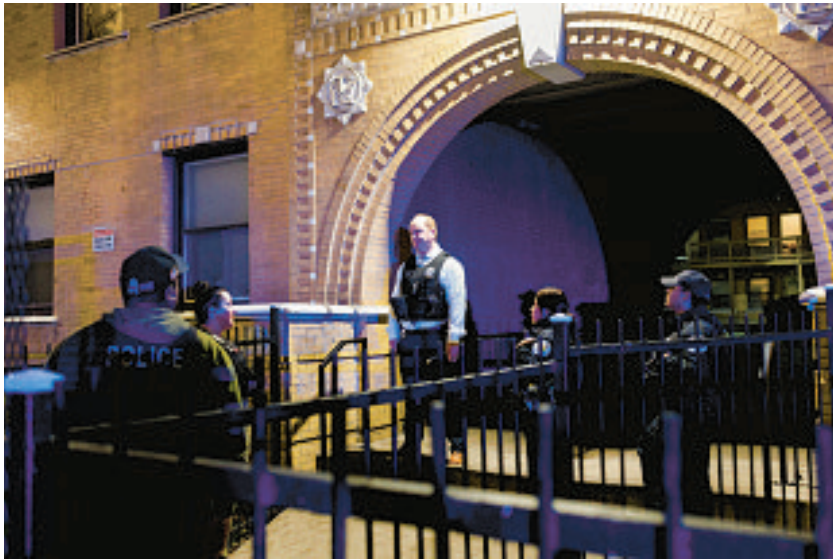
A recent morning, the 30-year-old Venezuelan stood in his kitchen and propped his toddler daughter up over his shoulder. He and his wife had run several extension cords outside for electricity. Bare bulbs and wires hung down from the ceiling, several feet above the head of their 4-year-old — who is named Milagro, Spanish for “miracle.”

“We left (Venezuela) because of the violence and the chaos. And now, we’ve found ourselves again in the middle of chaos,” Sanchez said. “We really didn’t expect this to happen when we entered the United States.”

After migrants started coming to Chicago in 2022, state agencies launched a program that helped those staying in shelters resettle into rental housing. Migrants generally moved to the South and West sides, where some have encountered patterns of violence and chaos similar to what they risked everything to leave behind.

Sanchez said his kids can’t go out alone because of frequent shootings near the building where they live in Washington Park. Other migrant families with no other affordable options have settled there too.

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Top: Kelvis Sanchez holds his daughter Milagro Sofia Sanchez, 4, while his wife, Yorgelis Rangel, holds their daughter Antonella Sanchez, 2, after waking up at their apartment in Washington Park in Chicago on Nov. 27. **Above:** Chicago police officers work the scene where a man was shot in the back and neck inside an apartment building in the 6100 block of South King Drive in Chicago’s Washington Park neighborhood on Nov. 19. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE PHOTOS**

MICHAEL MADIGAN TRIAL

Ex-speaker walking a tightrope by testifying



Former House Speaker Michael Madigan leaves the Dirksen U.S. Courthouse in Chicago on Tuesday during his ongoing corruption trial. **CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Will gamble pay off in high-stakes federal corruption trial?

By Ray Long, Jason Meisner
and Megan Crepeau
Chicago Tribune

In the world of Springfield politics, longtime House Speaker Michael Madigan developed a reputation that people at the statehouse could count on his word.

The secretive Southwest Side Democrat didn’t necessarily give it freely. He wanted to know every angle of an issue before saying he would embrace an idea or go all in. And he sometimes took his time before he would

sign on to a budget deal or agree to back a bill.

But governors, lawmakers and lobbyists time and again came to a consensus during Madigan’s five decades in the Illinois House, including a national-record 36 years as speaker: Whether you agreed with him or not, his word was good.

Now, four years after resigning his seat in the legislature amid a burgeoning federal corruption investigation, Madigan is banking on his word once again. But this time, it’s not fellow lawmakers or ward heelers he’s dealing with, it’s a jury of 12 average citizens. And the stakes couldn’t be higher.

Turn to Trial, Page 8

INSIDE



STACEY WESCOTT/TRIBUNE

Assessing the hunt for new Bears coach

The search, wide open as it begins, will be judged by the final hire. Can Ryan Poles and Kevin Warren deliver a slam dunk? **Chicago Sports**

Battle rages on to contain LA fires

Firefighters race to cut off wildfires before strong winds return, while evacuation warnings have people on edge. **Nation & World**

